

Switzerland: Canton flags

In every case the flags are based on the arms of the canton, some of which predate the canton's joining the Swiss Confederation.



AARGAU

Adopted in 1803, the white waves on black represent the River Aare, and the white stars on blue, the districts of Baden, the Free Areas, and Fricktal, which came together to form the canton. In 1963 it was decreed that the stars should be arranged 2 and 1.



APPENZELL INNER-RHODEN

This is the original form of the flag before the partition from Appenzell Ausser-Rhoden in 1597. The bear emblem was widely used locally in the Middle Ages, and was taken by the Appenzellers from the arms of the abbey of Sankt Gallen.



BASEL-STADT

The emblem of Basel-Stadt is the headpiece of a bishop's crozier. The emblem dates back to the earliest days of heraldry. Since the 15th century it has been depicted as black on white. It was kept in this form when the canton was divided in 1832.



APPENZELL AUSSER-RHODEN

Adopted in 1597 when the canton separated from the Inner-Rhoden, the flag retained the bear, but added the initials VR (for Usserden). The bear dates back to medieval banners. It was used from 1403 in battles against feudal landlords.



BASEL-LAND

Basel-Land separated from the City in 1832. The arms and flag were adopted in 1834 based on the form of crozier used in Liestal, with the crook turned to the right and decorated with small spheres. This was made official in 1947.



BERN

The coat of arms dates back to the 12th century. Soon after which the arms, which depict a bear on a red field with a yellow diagonal, became the canton's banner. There have, however, been many variant forms through the ages. The bear represents the name of the canton.